

Βίων ὁ Βορυσθενίτης

Bion of Borysthenes and the Cynic Life

eul_aid: hks

Period: [Κλασική](#) [Classical](#)
Dialect: [Κοινή](#) [Koine](#) (phi, frg)
Domain: [Φιλοσοφία](#) [Philosophy](#)
Format: [Πραγματεία](#) [Treatise](#)
Affiliation: [Cynic](#)

Bion of Borysthenes was a Hellenistic philosopher of the 3rd century BCE. He was born in the Greek colony of Olbia on the Black Sea. Ancient accounts describe a difficult early life: his father was a freedman and his mother a prostitute, and Bion was sold into slavery as a youth. He was later purchased and freed by a rhetorician, whose inheritance allowed Bion to travel to Athens to study philosophy.

In Athens, he studied under several schools but ultimately became a follower of the Cynics, particularly Crates of Thebes. He later served as a philosophical advisor at the Macedonian court of King Antigonos II Gonatas. He died in Chalcis.

Bion wrote no surviving complete works. He was famous for his diatribes—popular, satirical moral lectures that blended serious ethics with humor and streetwise rhetoric. These works survive only in fragments and paraphrases quoted by later authors. According to modern scholars, Bion is significant for popularizing Cynic and Stoic ideas. His innovative, accessible style is seen as a key influence on later Hellenistic philosophers and the Roman poet Horace. His life story was often cited in antiquity as an example of philosophy's power to overcome humble origins.

Works (2)

- [Ἐπιτάφιος Ἀδώνιδος](#) · [Bion's Philosophical Autobiography](#) · 101 passages
- [Αποσπάσματα](#) · [Fragments on Archytas](#) · 2 passages

Other Cynic Authors

- [Ἀντισθένης ὁ Ἀθηναῖος](#) · [Antisthenes of Athens I](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀντισθένης ὁ Ἀθηναῖος](#) · [Antisthenes of Athens II](#) · 2 works
- [Κράτης ὁ Θεβαῖος](#) · [Crates of Thebes I](#) · 1 work
- [Δημώναξ ὁ Κύπριος](#) · [Demonax of Cyprus](#) · 1 work
- [Διογένης ὁ Σινωπεύς](#) · [Diogenes of Sinope](#) · 1 work
- [Διοτογένης ὁ φιλόσοφος](#) · [Diotogenes the Philosopher](#) · 1 work
- [Μόνιμος ὁ Συρακόσιος](#) · [Monimus of Syracuse](#) · 1 work
- [Νίκαρχος ὁ Σινωπεύς](#) · [Nikarchos of Sinope](#) · 1 work
- [Οἰνόμαος ὁ Γαδαρεύς](#) · [Oenomaus of Gadara](#) · 1 work

- Σεκούνδος ὁ Σιωπηλός · *Secundus the Silent* · 2 works
- Τέλης ὁ Μεγαρεύς · *Teles of Megara* · 8 works